MONEY ADMIN

Bills, Renewals & Subscriptions

Dates first. Shame later.

Not a budget makeover. A calmer map of what leaves your account, when it leaves, and what you can safely ignore until next month.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01 A due-date map and autopay audit
02 A twelve-month renewal calendar
03 A subscription rescue plan
04 Scripts for tight months and cancellations
05 Privacy-safe AI prompts for money admin

PLAIN *ENGLISH* ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
Make it yours.

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Dates before amounts

Most money admin dread comes from not knowing what is coming. The amount matters, but the date is what turns a quiet week into a late fee. This planner starts with dates because a calendar is easier to face than a spreadsheet full of judgement.

> WATCH OUT
>
> **This is education, not financial advice**
>
> This guide helps you organise reminders and paperwork. It cannot decide what you can afford, which debt strategy is right for you, or how a local benefit works. For those decisions, use a qualified professional, a nonprofit credit counsellor, or an official government source. Never give a chatbot your bank login or card number.

Keep the sensitive numbers out

This sheet is designed to be useful without exposing your accounts. Write the biller and the due date. Use a nickname for the account if you need one. Do not write:

- Full account or card numbers.
- Passwords, PINs, or security answers.
- Your full government ID.
- Bank routing numbers.
- Screenshots of your banking app on a shared printer.

If you need the account number to call, look it up when you make the call. You do not need it copied onto a page that might sit on the kitchen table.

Three useful distinctions

Fixed vs. variable

Rent is fixed. A utility bill moves with the season. Variable bills need a reminder before the due date, not just a set-and-forget autopay.

Essential vs. flexible

Essential costs protect housing, food, health, transport, and basic connection. Flexible costs are real, but can often move or pause in a tight month. Sort without judging.

Autopay vs. autopilot

Autopay can prevent a late fee. Autopilot can hide a price increase for years. A good system checks both the payment and the amount.

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The four-part routine

01 **Map:** list the biller, due date, payment method, and where the statement lives.

02 **Check:** once a month, confirm autopays cleared and amounts are plausible.

03 **Calendar:** put annual renewals and variable bills where they will actually be seen.

04 **Reset:** once a quarter, question one subscription and update one contact detail.

That is the whole system. It does not require a colour-coded budget binder. It requires a place to look.

What this planner is not

It is not a complete financial plan. It is not a record of every purchase. It is not a substitute for a bank statement. It is the layer that helps you stop being surprised by the same six dates every month.

My version of the routine

PART	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE HERE	WHEN I WILL DO IT
Map		
Check		
Calendar		
Reset		

The one part I will start with

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The due-date map

Fill in the bills that repeat. Use the due date or the typical day. If autopay is on, verify it in the source account — do not assume it is still working because you set it up years ago.

BILL OR PAYMENT	DUE DAY	HOW IT IS PAID	AUTOPAY?	WHERE I CHECK IT	LAST CONFIRMED
Housing					
Utilities					
Phone / internet					
Insurance					
Prescriptions / health costs					
Debt minimums					
Subscriptions					
Other					
Other					

The week-before check

Choose one day each month — payday, a quiet Sunday, or the same day as another routine. Spend ten minutes on these five checks.

- ☐ Look at the next two weeks of due dates.
- ☐ Confirm the money for automatic payments is available.
- ☐ Check for price changes or unusual amounts.
- ☐ Look for a bill that never arrived.
- ☐ Move one action to the calendar if it needs a call.

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If a bill is missing

A missing bill is not a free month. Check the provider’s app or website, your email spam folder, or the last statement. If the account normally arrives by post and it has not, contact the provider. Do not wait for a late fee to prove the point.

> TRY THIS
>
> **The two-place rule**
>
> Put the due date in your calendar and keep one visible list. Two places are easier to trust than a system so clever you cannot remember where the system is. If the calendar and the list disagree, the provider’s statement wins.

My monthly check day

Bills that need a phone call

BILLER	WHAT I NEED TO ASK	PHONE OR CONTACT	BEST TIME TO CALL

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The autopay audit

Autopay is a tool, not a personality. It reduces effort and can also hide drift: a subscription renews at a new price, a bill gets charged twice, or a card expires and the payment silently fails. A short audit turns autopilot back into a choice.

Once a month

- ☐ Log in to the payment account directly, not through an email link.
- ☐ Scan the last 30 days for recurring charges.
- ☐ Match each charge to a bill or subscription.
- ☐ Flag anything you do not recognise.
- ☐ Check that the funding source is current.
- ☐ Look for duplicate services doing the same job.
- ☐ Note any amount that changed.

Once a year

- ☐ Recheck insurance, phone, internet, software, storage, and memberships.
- ☐ Look at the renewal price, not only the introductory price.
- ☐ Check whether a free trial will become a paid plan.
- ☐ Confirm the cancellation window and process.
- ☐ Update the card or account if it has changed.

The failed-payment checklist

If an autopay fails, deal with the payment first and the feelings second. Banks and providers can charge fees that grow quickly.

01 Confirm what failed and when.

02 Make the payment manually if it is safe and possible.

03 Check whether the provider charges a late fee or reports the missed payment.

04 Update the expired card or insufficient balance issue.

05 Turn on an earlier reminder for next month.

If a failed payment leads to a service shutoff or a debt you cannot manage, contact the provider or a qualified local service. Do not use a high-cost “fix” from an unsolicited message.

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My autopay rules

- ☐ Every recurring charge is listed on the due-date map.
- ☐ Automatic payments have at least a small buffer in the account.
- ☐ I know how to cancel each service I pay for.
- ☐ I check for trial-to-paid conversions after signing up.
- ☐ I review one old subscription every quarter.

One charge I will investigate

GOOD TO KNOW

You can turn autopay off

If an automatic payment is causing anxiety, you are allowed to switch to manual payments with calendar reminders — as long as you have a plan for the due date. There is no single correct method. There is only a method you will check.

My autopay review

BILL OR SERVICE	WHERE I CHECK IT	HOW OFTEN	NEXT CHECK

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The renewal calendar

Annual renewals are easy to forget because they do not happen often enough to become routine. Put them in one place. Add the date you expect the charge, the likely amount, and the action you need to take before it renews.

MONTH	RENEWAL OR ANNUAL COST	EXPECTED AMOUNT	CHECK ON	ACTION
January				
February				
March				
April				
May				
June				
July				
August				
September				
October				
November				
December				

Renewals people often miss

- Insurance policies, unless escrowed or bundled.
- Professional licences, registrations, and certifications.
- Domain names, website hosting, and email services.
- Cloud storage and software plans.
- Memberships, warehouse clubs, and annual passes.
- Subscriptions bought for a single project.
- Warranties or service plans that auto-renew.
- Season passes, tickets, and pre-paid plans.

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The 30-day rule

Put a calendar reminder 30 days before a known annual renewal. At the reminder, answer three questions:

01 Do I still use this?

02 Has the price changed?

03 If I want to cancel or switch, what is the deadline and process?

If the answer is “I don’t know,” the reminder becomes a small research task: find the renewal terms and the cancellation route. That is enough for today.

The renewal note

SERVICE	RENEWAL DATE	PRICE LAST YEAR	PRICE THIS YEAR	KEEP / CANCEL / COMPARE

TRY THIS

Add the renewal to your calendar as an appointment

“Check car insurance” is easier to act on than “insurance stuff.” Put the specific action in the calendar event, along with a link to the account page or the phone number.

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The subscription rescue

Subscriptions are designed to be frictionless to start and slightly awkward to stop. A rescue is not about cancelling everything. It is about making the cost visible and choosing what earns its place.

Step 1 · Find them

Check three places:

- **Bank and card statements:** look for small recurring charges, annual renewals, and app-store charges.
- **App store subscriptions:** many in-app plans are billed there, not by the company directly.
- **Email inbox:** search for “receipt,” “renewal,” “subscription,” and “trial.”

Step 2 · Sort into three piles

KEEP	PAUSE / COMPARE	CANCEL
I use it most weeks and the current price makes sense.	I use it occasionally, or the price changed, or I need to compare a better option.	I forgot it existed, it no longer fits, or the free alternative is enough.

Step 3 · Cancel without a scavenger hunt

01 Find the service in the source where it is billed — app store, website, or provider account.

02 Look for Subscription, Billing, Plan, or Manage membership.

03 Check whether cancellation is immediate or runs to the end of the paid period.

04 Save the confirmation email or screenshot.

05 Remove the payment method from the service if that is available and appropriate.

06 Put a calendar note to check that no further charge appears.

If a service makes cancellation difficult, check the provider’s official help pages and your local consumer protection resources. Do not use a “cancellation service” that asks for your banking password.

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Step 4 · Make the keep decision honest

A subscription can be worth it even if you do not use it every day. The question is not “Am I using this enough to deserve it?” It is “If I were signing up today, would I choose this at this price?” If the answer is no, pause or cancel.

My one rescue action

WATCH OUT

Free trials are still financial commitments

Put the cancellation date in your calendar the day you start a trial — not when you remember. If a trial requires a card, decide now whether you actually intend to keep the paid plan.

The keep question

SUBSCRIPTION	WOULD I SIGN UP AGAIN TODAY AT THIS PRICE?	KEEP / PAUSE / CANCEL	NEXT STEP

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The tight month

When money is short, the goal is not to create a perfect plan under pressure. It is to protect the essentials, buy time where you can, and avoid decisions that make next month worse.

This page is organisation, not financial advice. Local programs, legal protections, and benefit rules vary. Use an official service or qualified adviser for your specific situation.

GOOD TO KNOW

Stop and get qualified help if

You are facing eviction, foreclosure, utility shutoff, legal action, or a debt you cannot manage; you are considering a high-cost loan or a “debt relief” offer; or you are skipping food or medicine to pay something else. Contact a local emergency service, a nonprofit credit counsellor, or an official benefits office. Do not rely on a chatbot for this.

Sort the month into three lanes

PROTECT	PAUSE OR REDUCE	ASK ABOUT
Housing, food, health care, basic transport, essential utilities, minimum payments that carry serious consequences	Subscriptions, memberships, optional upgrades, non-urgent purchases	Payment plans, hardship programs, grace periods, local assistance, billing errors

The contact script

Use the phone or official website on your bill or statement. Do not use the contact details from an unexpected text message.

> “I’m having difficulty paying this bill. I want to understand my options before the due date. Can you tell me about payment plans, a due-date change, or hardship assistance? What do you need from me, and will this affect my account?”

Write down the date, the person or reference number, and what they said. If you are not sure the answer is right, ask them to send it in writing or point you to the official policy.

The “do not make it worse” list

- Do not ignore a shutoff or legal notice because it is frightening.
- Do not take a high-interest loan without understanding the total repayment.
- Do not pay an unsolicited “debt fixer” upfront.
- Do not share bank passwords with anyone who offers to sort it for you.
- Do not use AI to invent eligibility or legal claims.

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My tight-month plan

What is protected first:

Who I need to contact, and by when:

What I am pausing or cancelling:

Who can help me review this:

Calls to make

WHO	ABOUT	BY WHEN	DONE
			☐
			☐
			☐

What I am not deciding today

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Ask AI without oversharing

AI can be useful for the organisational layer of money admin: building a bill calendar from dates you type, explaining a fee in plain English, drafting a call script, or turning a list into a checklist. It cannot verify your balance, access your bank, or make a financial decision for you.

WATCH OUT

The privacy line

Never paste bank logins, full account or card numbers, routing numbers, government IDs, security answers, or screenshots of your banking app into a general consumer AI tool. Redact names and exact account details. Use rounded amounts if you need help planning.

Prompt: build a reminder schedule

PROMPT RECIPE — TURN DATES INTO A REMINDER PLAN

Here is a list of recurring bills with only the names, due days, and whether the amount is fixed or variable. Do not ask for account numbers or balances.

Bills:
- [bill name] — due day [number] — [fixed/variable]
- [bill name] — due day [number] — [fixed/variable]

Make me a monthly reminder checklist. For each bill, say what to verify one week before the date. Put annual renewals in a separate list. Keep it to one page and do not invent any amounts.

Prompt: understand a fee

PROMPT RECIPE — EXPLAIN THIS CHARGE WITHOUT FINANCIAL ADVICE

I received this description of a fee: [paste only the generic description, with names and account numbers removed]. Explain what this kind of fee usually means in plain English, what questions I should ask the provider, and what information I should have ready. Do not tell me whether to pay it.

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Prompt: draft a call script

PROMPT RECIPE — PREPARE ME FOR A BILLING CALL

I need to call [provider type] about [problem]. I want to ask about [payment plan / due date / billing error / cancellation]. I am not asking for financial advice. Give me a short opening line, five questions to ask, what written confirmation to request, and a place to record the answer. Do not invent policy details or eligibility rules.

Before the call

- ☐ I have the bill or statement in front of me.
- ☐ I know the date of service or the account nickname.
- ☐ I know the one question I need answered.
- ☐ I have a pen and somewhere to record the answer.
- ☐ I know what I will do if they cannot help today.

The call record

DATE	WHO I SPOKE TO	REFERENCE	WHAT THEY SAID	NEXT STEP

Verify before you act

AI may be outdated, wrong, or confident about a rule that does not exist. Check the provider's official website, your statement, or a qualified human. The useful output is a clearer question or a better list — not an authority.

My safe AI use rule

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The 15-minute monthly reset

Put this on the calendar as an appointment. Fifteen minutes once a month is enough to catch most avoidable surprises. If fifteen minutes is too much, do the first five.

Minutes 0–5 · Look

- ☐ Open the due-date map.
- ☐ Check the next 30 days.
- ☐ Scan recent recurring charges.
- ☐ Notice anything unrecognised or newly expensive.

Minutes 5–10 · Act

- ☐ Schedule one necessary call or payment.
- ☐ Cancel or pause one thing that no longer earns its place.
- ☐ Update one renewal date or contact detail.
- ☐ Move one action into the calendar with a specific verb.

Minutes 10–15 · Close

- ☐ Write what changed.
- ☐ Put the sheet back where you will see it.
- ☐ Choose the next reset date.
- ☐ Stop.

The monthly reset log

MONTH	ONE THING CHECKED	ONE THING CHANGED	NEXT RESET

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The low-energy version

If a full reset is impossible, choose one:

- Check the next due date.
- Verify one autopay.
- Cancel one subscription.
- Open one bill and write one action.
- Ask someone to sit with you while you make one call.

A partial check is still a check. The goal is not to become the kind of person who loves financial admin. The goal is to hear the due date before it becomes a late fee.

The one thing I will do

What I will ask someone else to do

My next small step

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Enough awareness to breathe

Money admin is not a measure of your worth. It is a set of recurring logistics that can be made more visible, more predictable, and less personal. A due-date map and a fifteen-minute appointment will not solve every financial problem. They can stop the same surprise from arriving every month.

The one-page takeaway

- Dates first; amounts can follow.
- Keep account numbers off worksheets.
- Autopay needs an audit, not blind trust.
- Put annual renewals in a calendar with a specific action.
- In a tight month, protect the essentials and ask early.
- Use AI for wording and organisation, never for bank access or decisions.

My next small step

GOOD TO KNOW

A final permission slip

You do not need to love money admin to be good at one small part of it. Start with the next date.

ONE LAST THING · 09

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Open your last statement or banking app and copy only the rounded recurring amounts and due dates onto the due-date map. Never write full account numbers on this sheet.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

A system should fit your real energy, not the other way around. Keep what helps, drop what becomes another chore, and let the next small step be enough.

More life-admin printables

- 07 The Low-Energy Weekly Reset
- 08 The Paper Pile Triage Kit
- 10 The Appointment Companion
- 11 The Low-Energy Meal Plan
- 12 The Household Command Center

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Keep the useful part. Leave the rest.